

RIBBON - 290210 Assignment 2B: Playtest - May 19th 2025

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Feedback / Development Response

This document is a quick update looking at the recent playtest - design developments since (and based around) data gathered from last week's test.

Ribbon is effectively a walking sim, designed around a more ambient play experience than what might be considered contemporary, as a vessel I want to use to explore personal mechanical and audiovisual ideas that could be developed further in continuing semesters, years, or in my own time among other game projects I have started.

Because of that, I wanted to collect data focused on the abstract nature and concepts ahead of what currently exists, supplementing my goals through measurable responses to the presentation and wider context of RIBBON through means that can inform actionable guided development direction.

By nature, "walking sims" (and comparative projects like it) often attract an alternate, significantly *smaller* demographic than current trending genres (for example: action-adventure or first-person shooter games), and tend to be perceived as less involved or less stimulating in comparison for it.

I intend for a lot of Ribbon's entertainment to stem from the presentation with an audio focus, structured out in design notes (though still to be produced) and likely to be finalized last of all significant mechanics in tuning them to "feel" right.

Previously recorded footage of an earlier build of the game ([YouTube: RIBBON - "Greybox"](#)), was presented alongside a real-time demo station with two running builds next to this survey, featuring updated or adjusted visuals and movement, a static mockup for the intended information HUD and upgraded static world lighting. The intent was to let testers respond to an early, but *core-representative* feeling for the game's direction in presentation as yet without audio (to be a key focus) after which they were able to map down survey responses according to their experience to better understand what felt like either an attraction, or a missing component to player expectation.

Following are each of the presented survey fields, and the corresponding data of their responses.

Analysis + details on next pages)

The first form field discerns immediate unbiased reactions from the live build + demo footage, the intent being to draw out testers to take a first step in what *they* felt their takeaway from RIBBON was:

What, to you, does the most important *gameplay* element of RIBBON seem to be?

7 responses

Discovery and Exploration

I have no clue, the game just looks cool. I think with whatever you do, you'll cook a storm up

story?

The lighting and the sapcious enviroment of the game is what draws me to the game. You said that it is going to be audio heavy so,,, i cant wait for that!

i like the visuals a lot, very pretty and fuctional. id like to hear the soundsss

movement, getting from one place to another with the gliding

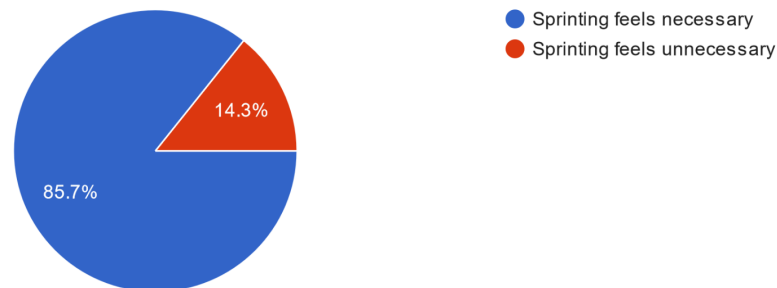
the experience of playing

These initial responses provide a great first base. My main relief was the (admittedly small) sample pool indicating a perhaps more amicable "open-mindedness" than I expected to what even *I* believe at first appearance appears to be a physically larger, but implementationally minimal world.

I anticipated that lacking action elements or faster pacing would present challenges to reach positive players first impressions. The following fields probe for specific opinions on the gameplay:

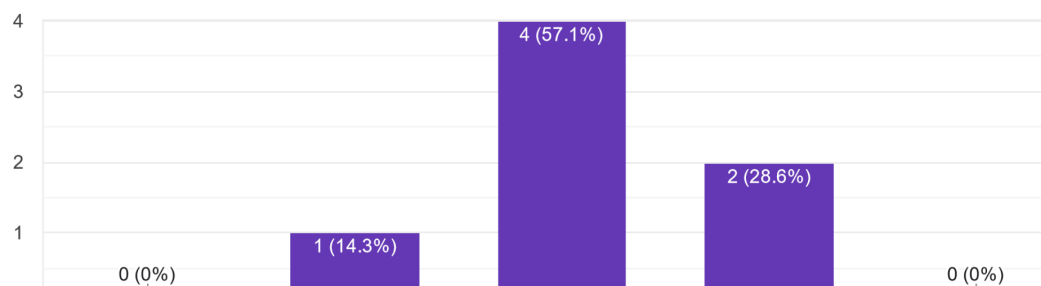
RIBBON is built around the journey of moving through each world. The character moves slower than a sprint, but can glide down from higher altitudes....ry mechanic that you would expect to be included?

7 responses

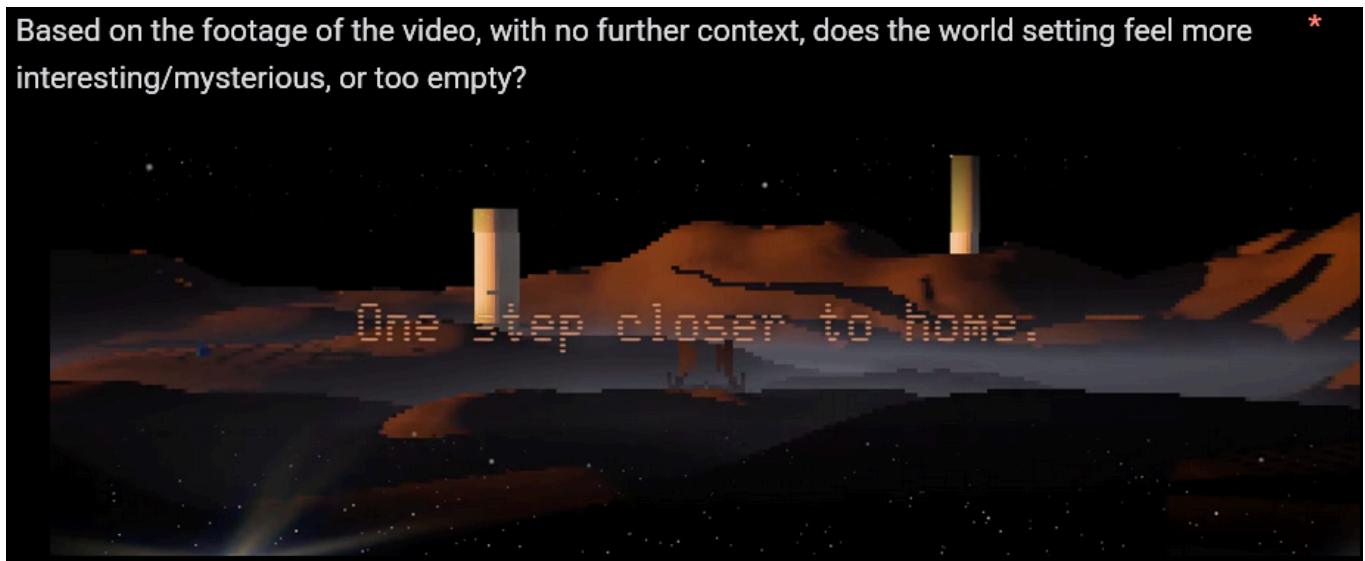


"You need to explore the world for runes with parts of a randomly generated code sequence, and power the gateway by activating the correct pylons....e, about right or too complicated of a game loop?

7 responses

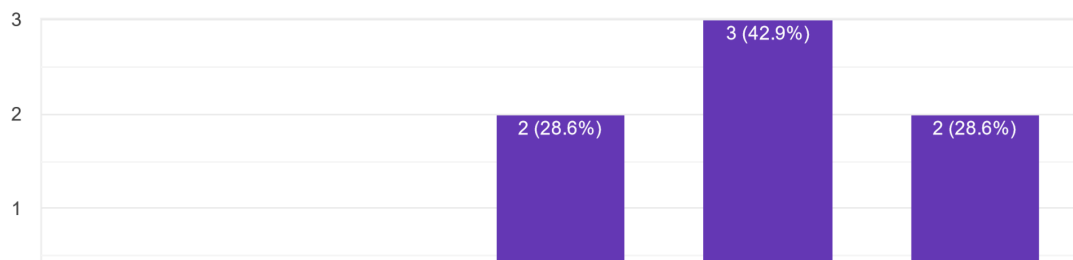


The next question touches on the *setting* of Ribbon, and the wider idea explained in the video + addressed to testers as they were exploring the build.



Based on the footage of the video, with no further context, does the world setting feel more interesting/mysterious, or too empty?

7 responses

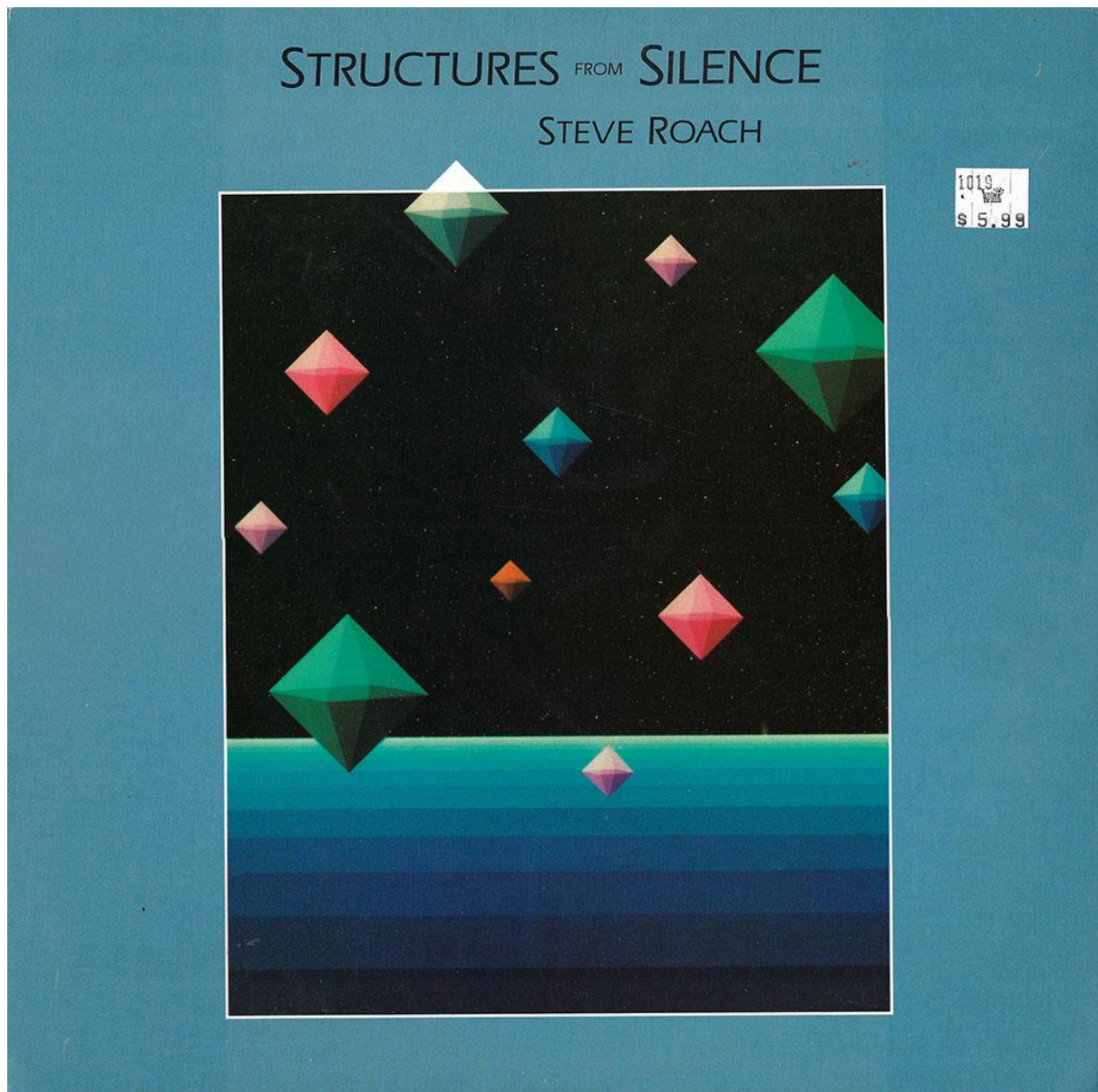


These results help to indicate that there is a positive skew between how the setting and presentation work together. Ultimately, *genuine* emptiness is not the goal here, the intent is for presentation and game mechanics to complement each other by offering substance *through* a representation of space.

This question touched on if there was a preference for “true” retro or retro-styled visuals, partially to gather interest for or against the use of more detailed surfaces and objects. An alternate benefit is that embracing this style in some ways can avoid the necessity for complicated graphical assets.

I discovered this game after my prior presentation, but “The Sentinel” is a puzzle adventure game that adopts what could be seen as a primitive form of a similar aesthetic.

Originally I intended for Ribbon to be completely “flat” shaded and more specifically retro, partially inspired by older movies with 80’s computer graphics such as TRON, or the album art of one of my favourite ambient albums by Steve Roach (pictured below):

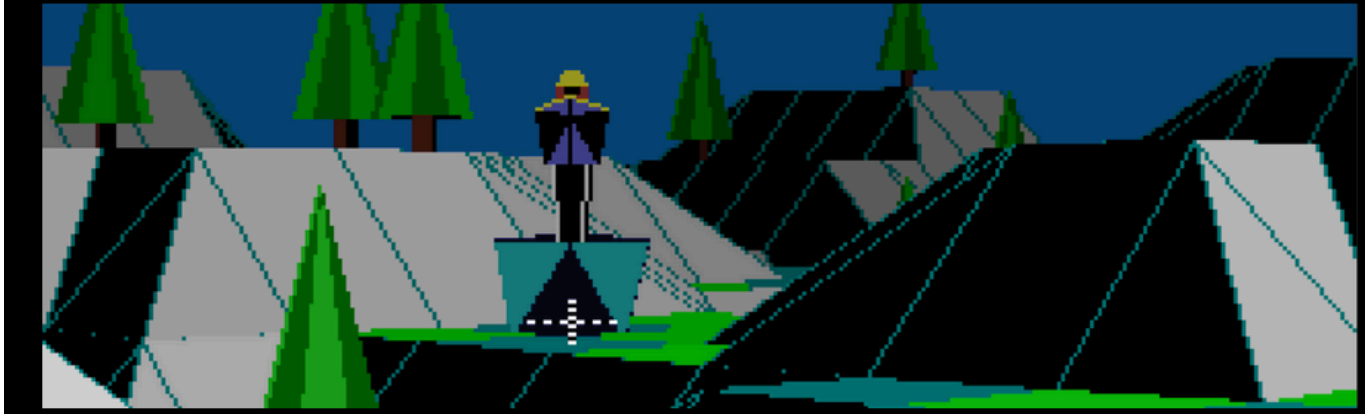


I “accidentally” discovered a feature to create a “volumetric wash” effect throughout the dunes of the first test level, and personally quite liked it, and so my stance on how to approach visual loosened slightly on the side of “authenticity”, should I find a happy medium that stylistically gives RIBBON a visual identity, while incorporating whatever lesser or greater rendering tricks or artistic approaches server the ultimate purpose of a memorable experience.

Elements of RIBBON are inspired by older 80's computer graphics, namely a use of simple surfaces, shapes, and a low, chunkier render resolution. *

If games that adopt a retro style appeal to you, do you prefer them to be loosely, or faithfully presented?

[Screenshot from The Sentinel (1986), Atari ST]



Elements of RIBBON are inspired by older 80's computer graphics, namely a use of simple surfaces, shapes, and a low, chunkier render resolution. If g...d? [Screenshot from The Sentinel (1986), Atari ST]

7 responses



As seen above, the majority of survey candidates generally aren't worried with strict adherence to "limited" render styles by authenticity, or find a looser definition may be more preferable.

These two questions focus on additional:

Ribbon will feature a dynamic element to the musical score tying into active gameplay, but because the demo did not yet feature audio elements in any form whatsoever. I wanted to look into how the current “missing piece” would be considered as a separate, additive element to presentation, versus an integral part of it. While I expected most people would respond in the ideal form for this game (that it is important), I still thought it would be a good question to map down.

How important does interactive sound feel to you, in terms of interactive experiences? (In any interpretation you may have of this question)

7 responses



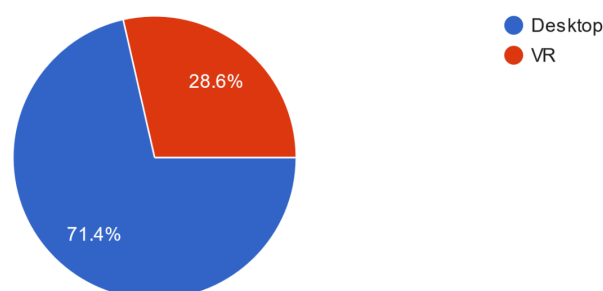
Last year (2024), I created a project called Monument, an intended VR reconstruction of the park area that evolved into a more abstract virtual “island”. The active user could walk around, though the island was empty and the project did not have true gameplay. This was my first (and currently) only time experimenting with VR application development, and although I personally do not have depth perception, I found that engaging in a fully enclosed VR headset environment provided not just a surprising, but unexpectedly *shocking* immersive experience. I’m intrigued by the future of VR and the advantages and opportunities exclusively possible through the extended dimension of agency and interaction provided by a VR interface.

While I do not own a headset to develop for, I was curious what the response would be to suggest VR interfacing into Ribbon. As someone that was personally indifferent or unconvinced by VR until trying experiences first-hand, my guess would be that most subjects with no VR experience would likewise, not be as receptive as those that are familiar.

I do not expect to have the time or resources to build VR support into the version for this assessment, but may explore it later in the year in my own time. Monument was built in Godot, which uses a different interface for VR functionality compared to Unreal, and I would need to refamiliarize myself with these functions to develop anything effectively.

RIBBON is designed to be accommodating, should the game develop in a way to support VR. Given the choice, would you prefer to play this game in a desktop or VR experience?

7 responses



Finally I left two “open floor” entries, one focused for gameplay, and the other focused for presentation. Here are the resulting survey entries for each field.

Based on what you've seen, is there anything you particularly liked, disliked or want to see more of about the **game loop**?

7 responses

At the moment it just feels a little slow, like it takes me a while to get anywhere, but otherwise I like the gameplay loop in mind

Nothing

i liked the concept but i genuinely had no idea what was happening

to me, it seems like a fairly simple concept. At least on its early builds.

i think it sound like fun, you might simply wanna add a sprint function that lets u glide so u can move faster across longer terrains. either that or add random trinkets to explore so the player doesnt just keep moving for too long expanses of planet

i think for a game so focused on movement, its very big, and because of that scale it does feel somewhat empty at the moment.

I really like how the world looked it's very cool to look at

Based on what you've seen, is there anything you particularly liked, disliked or want to see more of about the **graphics and sound**?

7 responses

I like the things that stand out, especially in something void adjacent, so adding something to break up the landscape VERY occasionally would be a cool surprise/discovery

I didn't hear anything today

graphics were cool. i liked the way you had done them

I would love to listen to the sound design of the game. It looked to be a big thing of the game that would put it together. the graphics of the game feels very nostalgic!!! yayyy

loved the graphics dude. would love to hear the sound

i think its a super cool unique style, and i enjoyed playing!

I like how it is and am excited to play more

In conclusion, I enter the next stage of RIBBON dev with the following data points:

- Players do find the presentation direction to be attractive. It's difficult to tell where audio places as a priority since audio does not yet exist, but there is additional intrigue to hear how sound will play a part in both gameplay and the presentation.
- The abstract or idea of an "older graphical style" is interesting, and most players do not mind a more generous approach to exploring it, as opposed to something "authentically accurate."
- More gameplay in the actual world, both goals or points of interest to move toward, and refining the feeling of movement itself would both be valuable improvements.

For items immediately actionable or for which design iterations began after this test, my next steps:

- Player movement is being adjusted, so that a system will increase movement acceleration over time. I plan to look into a system that adjusts movement acceleration based on how close you are to any points of interest on the level, so you "invisibly" move faster over patches of "nothing", or additional visual cues will help to provide a perceived sense of speed. Gliding will "always be usable", meaning that momentum could be build up over a long period to take jumps off of level inclines, and use that to horizontally soar further than directly on the ground.
- New models and general actor blueprints for objects of interest, so that I can begin to put in functions for interaction specific to each instance of these objects, and track game variables accordingly for overall level progress. I feel there needs to be some additional form of object encountered in the world, so I need to figure out what that'll be.
- I need to break down the actual player objectives of Ribbon into more digestible, simpler steps. Shortly before this test I started to piece together how I believe I want to approach the towers in relation to the portal, and progression of successive worlds. I need to simplify this, so that I can tackle each step effectively, and avoid player confusion.